

You better be worth it

Ever since ChatGPT came out about two years ago, artificial intelligence (AI) has permeated nearly every aspect of our lives, from personal assistants in our smartphones to sophisticated algorithms driving global industries. Among its many applications, AI-powered tools have become increasingly popular among students striving to manage the rigors of college coursework. While these tools offer undeniable convenience, they also present a concerning paradox: students may achieve high grades on assignments without truly grasping the underlying concepts, leading to a talent pool that is superficially qualified but fundamentally underprepared.

AI tools like advanced calculators such as Wolfram Alpha, language models, and research assistants have become integral to the modern student's toolkit. They can draft essays, solve complex equations, and even generate code snippets with remarkable accuracy. Yes, reasoning is still problematic for AI tools so they do get math wrong a lot of the times. But for time-strapped students juggling multiple responsibilities, the temptation to rely on these tools is understandable. After all, if a piece of software can produce a high-quality assignment in a fraction of the time, why not take advantage?

However, this convenience comes at a cost. When students outsource critical thinking and problem-solving to AI, they forgo the learning process that these assignments are designed to facilitate. The result is a generation of learners who may excel on paper but lack the depth of understanding required to apply their knowledge in practical settings.

Traditionally, there has been a recognized gap between coursework and examination performance. Coursework often allows for extended deadlines, collaboration, and access to resources, enabling students to produce polished work with higher grades. Examinations, on the other hand, test a student's ability to recall and apply knowledge under pressure without external aids.

The introduction of AI tools exacerbates this disconnect. Students who use AI to enhance their coursework might secure top marks, but when faced with an exam that requires



“Instead of discouraging the use of AI, educators could incorporate AI literacy into the curriculum.”

Mithun Mohandas
Managing Editor



Let me know your thoughts on this column at:
@mithun_mohandas |
mithun@digit.in

independent thought and problem-solving, their performance can falter. This discrepancy not only affects individual academic records but also raises questions about the validity of grades as a measure of competence since coursework tends to get a larger weightage in some marking systems.

The ramifications extend beyond academia into the workforce. Employers rely on academic credentials as indicators of a candidate's capabilities. If grades no longer accurately reflect a student's understanding, the talent pool becomes diluted with individuals who may not possess the skills their qualifications suggest.

Industries could face a crisis of competence, where employees are ill-equipped to handle the demands of their roles. This situation could lead to decreased productivity, increased training costs, and a potential loss of innovation. In fields where precision and expertise are critical—such as engineering, healthcare, and technology—the consequences could be even more severe.

Educational institutions are grappling with how to address this issue. Some are implementing stricter regulations and utilising plagiarism detection software that can identify AI-generated content. Others are redesigning assessments to focus more on in-person evaluations and practical applications of knowledge.

To mitigate these challenges, a reimagining of educational strategies is necessary. Instead of discouraging the use of AI, educators could incorporate AI literacy into the curriculum. Teaching students how to use AI responsibly can empower them to leverage these tools ethically and effectively. Institutes can also incorporate more assignments that require analysis, reflection, and personal insight are less susceptible to AI automation. By focusing on critical thinking skills, educators can encourage deeper engagement with the material. Incorporating more hands-on projects, presentations, and collaborative work can provide a more accurate gauge of a student's understanding and abilities. And if you can't beat 'em, join 'em. Utilise technology to create adaptive testing environments can help assess a student's knowledge more dynamically, reducing the disparity between coursework and exam performance. **d**